

Austin Khammanivong
Professor Powers
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Interview with a Paralegal

For this assignment, I conducted an interview with an intellectual property paralegal named Devon, who currently works in-house in New York. I found her through Reddit after posting in a paralegal forum, and she agreed to speak with me for about an hour and a half. She has been working in the legal field for around ten years and provided a lot of insight into both her career path and daily responsibilities.

When I asked how she got started, she explained that her path into the legal field was not very traditional. Although she has a background in history, she mentioned that it did not directly apply to her current role. Before becoming a paralegal, she worked several different jobs, including intellectual property-related work with YouTube, investment and funding management, and a legal administrative position. She emphasized that starting in an administrative role helped her gain experience and eventually transition into her first paralegal position in the intellectual property field.

She described her typical work week as very fast-paced and constantly changing depending on the needs of the company. Early in the week is usually focused on emails and communication with internal teams, especially marketing. During the middle of the week, she spends more time on data privacy work, such as reviewing platforms and making sure the company is complying with different state laws. Later in the week, she works on packaging and labeling issues, including trademark-related matters. Fridays tend to be lighter and more focused on deadlines and administrative tasks. Overall, she explained that her role is heavily administrative, including managing dockets, reviewing trademarks, and communicating with attorneys and internal departments.

One thing that stood out to me was the difference between working in-house and in a law firm. She explained that she actually preferred the law firm environment because everyone has a legal background, which makes communication easier. In-house work can be more challenging because she often has to explain legal concepts to people who are not familiar with the law. This requires strong communication skills and the ability to simplify complex information.

She also explained that her work involves a mix of intellectual property, marketing, and data privacy. Out of these areas, she enjoys data privacy the most because it is constantly evolving and varies from state to state. She finds marketing work less interesting, but still important when it comes to reviewing claims and ensuring compliance. This showed me how diverse a paralegal role can be, especially in a corporate setting.

In terms of daily responsibilities, she estimated that about 40 percent of her work involves legal research and 60 percent is administrative. Her research often includes reviewing customer complaints, competitor activity, and compliance issues. She also mentioned that some of her

responsibilities extend beyond normal work hours, especially when monitoring social media or vendor-related issues.

Another important takeaway from the interview was the importance of skills. She emphasized communication as one of the most important skills, especially being able to take complex legal information and present it in a way that others can easily understand. She also stressed the importance of double-checking everything, even your own work, and not making assumptions. She said this was something she learned over time and wished she focused on earlier in her career.

When discussing challenges, she mentioned that making mistakes is part of the learning process, especially when starting out. She explained that attorneys sometimes forget what it is like to be new, which can make the experience stressful. However, she advised that it is important to ask questions, accept feedback, and use mistakes as opportunities to improve. She also briefly mentioned the role of office politics and the importance of maintaining good relationships with coworkers.

The advice she gave me as someone just starting out was very helpful. She said not to put too much pressure on myself and to understand that I will not know everything right away. She recommended starting in a legal administrative role to build experience and figure out what area of law I am most interested in. She also emphasized that experience is what opens doors in the legal field, even more than certifications.

Overall, this interview helped me better understand what a paralegal actually does on a daily basis, especially in an in-house intellectual property role. It showed me that the job is not just about legal knowledge, but also about communication, organization, and adaptability. This interview also made me realize that there are multiple paths into the legal field, and that gaining experience early on is extremely important.

In terms of my own career goals, this interview reinforced my interest in becoming a paralegal. It also made me more open to starting in an administrative role to gain experience and work my way up. I also found the data privacy aspect of her job interesting, especially since it is a growing area of law. Overall, this experience gave me a clearer idea of what to expect in the profession and how I can begin building my career in the legal field.